

Jeremiah 16 - 18

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight we continue through Jeremiah - from a prophet forbidden to marry, mourn, or feast, to sin engraved with an iron pen, to a potter's wheel where a ruined vessel is worked again.

A man whose empty house becomes the sermon.

A heart so deceitful that only its Maker can read it - and a Maker who says He does.

A lump of clay that is marred in the potter's hand and is not thrown away.

Jeremiah 16 strips the prophet of ordinary life so that his loneliness itself preaches the coming silence of Judah - and then, in the same breath, promises a second exodus greater than the first.

Jeremiah 17 sets two men side by side: one a shrub in a salt land, the other a tree by the water - and traces the difference all the way down to where a person's trust actually rests, closing at the city gates with the Sabbath as the test case.

Jeremiah 18 takes us down to the potter's house, where Yahweh's sovereignty is shown to be not a fixed script but a working hand - and where the people answer the offer of mercy with "It is in vain," and begin plotting against the man who carried it.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 16 - A Life Emptied Out as a Sign

Key Notes

- Jeremiah is forbidden to marry or father children in that place - not as asceticism, but as a living sign: a generation is coming whose sons and daughters will die unlamented and unburied (Jeremiah 16:1-4).
- He is forbidden to enter the house of mourning, because Yahweh has withdrawn His shalom from this people - and with it His loving kindness and tender mercies (Jeremiah 16:5-7).
- He is equally forbidden the house of feasting: the voice of mirth and gladness, of bridegroom and bride, will cease before their own eyes and in their own days (Jeremiah 16:8-9).
- When the people ask "What is our iniquity?" the answer is not vague - their fathers forsook Yahweh and walked after other gods, and this generation has done worse than their fathers (Jeremiah 16:10-13).
- In the middle of the sentence comes an astonishing promise: a day when Israel's defining testimony will no longer be the exodus from Egypt but a greater gathering out of the land of the north (Jeremiah 16:14-15).
- Fishermen and hunters will be sent - a total, inescapable search - because Yahweh's eyes are on all their ways and their iniquity is not concealed from Him (Jeremiah 16:16-18).
- The chapter ends with the nations themselves coming from the ends of the earth, confessing that their fathers inherited nothing but lies, and learning that His name is Yahweh (Jeremiah 16:19-21).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Prophet's Life Made a Sign	Jeremiah 16:1-4 • Ezekiel 24:15-18 • Isaiah 8:18
Peace, Loving Kindness, and Mercy Withdrawn	Jeremiah 16:5 • Deuteronomy 31:17 • Hosea 1:6
The Voice of Bridegroom and Bride Silenced	Jeremiah 16:9 • Jeremiah 7:34 • Jeremiah 25:10
Worse Than Their Fathers	Jeremiah 16:11-12 • 2 Kings 21:9 • Jeremiah 7:26
A Second and Greater Exodus	Jeremiah 16:14-15 • Jeremiah 23:7-8 • Isaiah 43:18-19
Fishers and Hunters Sent Out	Jeremiah 16:16 • Amos 4:2 • Habakkuk 1:14-15
Nothing Hidden From Yahweh's Eyes	Jeremiah 16:17 • Proverbs 15:3 • Hebrews 4:13
The Nations Renouncing Inherited Lies	Jeremiah 16:19-21 • Isaiah 2:2-3 • Zechariah 8:23

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Prophet With No Home and No	Jeremiah 16:2 • Matthew 8:20 • Isaiah 53:3

Connection	References
Household	
The Bridegroom Whose Voice Is Heard Again	Jeremiah 16:9 • John 3:29 • Revelation 19:6-9
The Greater Exodus Accomplished at Jerusalem	Jeremiah 16:14-15 • Luke 9:31 • Romans 11:26-27
Fishers of Men - the Gathering Reversed	Jeremiah 16:16 • Matthew 4:19 • Mark 1:17
A Light to the Nations at the Ends of the Earth	Jeremiah 16:19 • Isaiah 49:6 • Acts 13:47
The Name Made Known and Confessed	Jeremiah 16:21 • John 17:6 • Philippians 2:9-11

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 16 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - verse-by-verse treatment of the marriage prohibition and the second-exodus promise
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 16](#) - Sabbath-keeping, Torah-honoring perspective on the covenant sign language of the chapter
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 16](#) - detailed exposition of the fishers-and-hunters oracle and the restoration promise

Jeremiah 16 - Opening Intro

Tonight Yahweh does something He has not yet done to Jeremiah. In chapter 13 He took a belt. In chapter 15 He took the prophet's peace. Here He takes his future - no wife, no children, no funerals, no weddings. The man himself becomes the object lesson, and the lesson is loneliness.

But notice where the chapter goes. In the middle of a sentence about exile, Yahweh interrupts Himself with a promise so large it will one day retire Israel's oldest testimony: the day is coming when people will no longer say "as Yahweh lives, who brought us out of Egypt," because something greater will have happened.

Before we read, hold this: the same God who empties a house can fill a nation. Judgment here is never the last word - it is the ground being cleared for a homecoming.

Jeremiah 16:1-21 (WEB)

1 Yahweh's word came also to me, saying,

2 “You shall not take a wife, neither shall you have sons or daughters, in this place.”^{1,2}

3 For Yahweh says concerning the sons and concerning the daughters who are born in this place, and concerning their mothers who bore them, and concerning their fathers who became their father in this land:

4 “They will die grievous deaths: they will not be lamented, neither will they be buried. They will be as dung on the surface of the ground. They will be consumed by the sword and by famine. Their dead bodies will be food for the birds of the sky and for the animals of the earth.”

5 For Yahweh says, “Don’t enter into the house of mourning. Don’t go to lament. Don’t bemoan them, for I have taken away my peace from this people,” says Yahweh, “even loving kindness and tender mercies.”³

6 Both great and small will die in this land. They will not be buried. Men won’t lament for them, cut themselves, or make themselves bald for them.

7 Men won’t break bread for them in mourning, to comfort them for the dead. Men won’t give them the cup of consolation to drink for their father or for their mother.

8 “You shall not go into the house of feasting to sit with them, to eat and to drink.”

9 For Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel says: “Behold, I will cause to cease out of this place, before your eyes and in your days, the voice of mirth and the voice of gladness, the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride.”⁴

10 It will happen, when you tell this people all these words, and they ask you, ‘Why has Yahweh pronounced all this great evil against us?’ or ‘What is our iniquity?’ or ‘What is our sin that we have committed against Yahweh our God?’⁵

11 then you shall tell them, ‘Because your fathers have forsaken me,’ says Yahweh, ‘and have walked after other gods, have served them, have worshiped them, have forsaken me, and have not kept my law.

12 You have done evil more than your fathers, for behold, you each walk after the stubbornness of his evil heart, so that you don’t listen to me.”⁶

13 Therefore will I cast you out of this land into the land that you have not known, neither you nor your fathers. There you will serve other gods day and night, for I will show you no favor.’

¹ Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 24:15-18](#) • [Isaiah 8:18](#) - the prophet’s own life and household made into a sign to the nation

² Messianic Connection: [Matthew 8:20](#) • [Isaiah 53:3](#) - the One with nowhere to lay His head, despised and rejected by men

³ Cross-Reference: [Deuteronomy 31:17](#) • [Hosea 1:6](#) - the hidden face and the withdrawal of covenant mercy from a people

⁴ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 7:34](#) • [Jeremiah 25:10](#) - the silencing of bridegroom and bride as the mark of a desolate land

⁵ Messianic Connection: [John 3:29](#) • [Revelation 19:6-9](#) - the Bridegroom whose voice returns at the marriage supper of the Lamb

⁶ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 21:9](#) • [Jeremiah 7:26](#) - each generation outdoing the last in stubbornness rather than repenting of it

14 “Therefore behold, the days come,” says Yahweh, “that it will no more be said, ‘As Yahweh lives, who brought up the children of Israel out of the land of Egypt;’

15 but, ‘As Yahweh lives, who brought up the children of Israel from the land of the north, and from all the countries where he had driven them.’ I will bring them again into their land that I gave to their fathers.^{7,8}

16 “Behold, I will send for many fishermen,” says Yahweh, “and they will fish them up. Afterward I will send for many hunters, and they will hunt them from every mountain, from every hill, and out of the clefts of the rocks.”⁹

17 For my eyes are on all their ways. They are not hidden from my face. Their iniquity isn’t concealed from my eyes.¹⁰

18 First I will recompense their iniquity and their sin double, because they have polluted my land with the carcasses of their detestable things, and have filled my inheritance with their abominations.”

19 Yahweh, my strength, and my stronghold, and my refuge in the day of affliction, the nations will come to you from the ends of the earth, and will say, “Our fathers have inherited nothing but lies, vanity and things in which there is no profit.”¹¹

20 Should a man make to himself gods, which yet are no gods?”

21 “Therefore behold, I will cause them to know, this once I will cause them to know my hand and my might. Then they will know that my name is Yahweh.”¹²

⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 23:7-8](#) • [Isaiah 43:18-19](#) - a second exodus that will eclipse the first as Israel's defining testimony

⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [Luke 9:31](#) • [Romans 11:26-27](#) - the exodus Yahshua accomplished at Jerusalem, and the Deliverer who comes out of Zion

⁹ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 4:19](#) • [Mark 1:17](#) - fishers sent out again - now to gather men in mercy rather than drag them off in judgment

¹⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Proverbs 15:3](#) • [Hebrews 4:13](#) - all things naked and laid open before the eyes of the One to whom we give account

¹¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 2:2-3](#) • [Zechariah 8:23](#) - the nations streaming to Yahweh in the latter days, taking hold of Israel's God

¹² **Messianic Connection:** [John 17:6](#) • [Philippians 2:9-11](#) - the Name revealed to those given Him, and confessed at last by every tongue

CHAPTER 17 - The Engraved Heart, the Two Trees, and the Sabbath Gate

Key Notes

- Judah's sin is written with an iron pen and a diamond point - engraved on the tablet of their heart and on the horns of their altars. Their worship itself carries the record of their guilt (Jeremiah 17:1-4).
- Two men are set side by side. Cursed is the man who trusts in man and relies on strength of flesh: he is a shrub in the desert who will not even recognize good when it arrives (Jeremiah 17:5-6).
- Blessed is the man whose confidence is in Yahweh: a tree planted by the waters, roots spread to the river, green in the heat and fruitful in the year of drought (Jeremiah 17:7-8).
- "The heart is deceitful above all things" is not despair but diagnosis - and it is immediately answered by the One who says, "I, Yahweh, search the mind. I try the heart" (Jeremiah 17:9-10).
- Riches gotten wrongly are like a partridge sitting on eggs she did not lay - they leave in the middle of life, and the end is folly (Jeremiah 17:11).
- Those who forsake Yahweh, the spring of living waters, are written in the earth - a name in dust, erased by the next wind (Jeremiah 17:12-13).
- Jeremiah prays the prayer that puts everything in the right hands: "Heal me, O Yahweh, and I will be healed. Save me, and I will be saved" (Jeremiah 17:14-18).
- The chapter closes at the city gates with a concrete test of covenant loyalty: bear no burden on the Sabbath. Obedience means an enduring city; refusal means an unquenched fire in its gates (Jeremiah 17:19-27).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Sin Engraved Where Torah Should Be	Jeremiah 17:1 • Job 19:24 • 2 Corinthians 3:3
Cursed: Trusting in the Strength of Flesh	Jeremiah 17:5 • Isaiah 31:1 • Psalm 118:8-9
Blessed: The Tree Planted by the Waters	Jeremiah 17:7-8 • Psalm 1:1-3 • Ezekiel 47:12
The Deceitful Heart	Jeremiah 17:9 • Genesis 6:5 • Mark 7:21-23
Yahweh Searches Mind and Heart	Jeremiah 17:10 • 1 Samuel 16:7 • 1 Chronicles 28:9
The Spring of Living Waters Forsaken	Jeremiah 17:13 • Jeremiah 2:13 • Psalm 36:9
Bearing No Burden on the Sabbath	Jeremiah 17:21-22 • Exodus 20:8-11 • Nehemiah 13:15-19
Sabbath Honored, the City Established	Jeremiah 17:24-26 • Isaiah 58:13-14 • Leviticus 26:2

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Torah Written Where Sin Was Engraved	Jeremiah 17:1 • Jeremiah 31:33 • Hebrews 8:10
The True Vine by the River of Life	Jeremiah 17:8 • John 15:1-5 • Revelation 22:1-2
The One Who Knew What Was in Man	Jeremiah 17:9-10 • John 2:24-25 • Revelation 2:23
Living Water Offered to the Thirsty	Jeremiah 17:13 • John 7:37-38 • John 4:14
Written in Earth or Written in Heaven	Jeremiah 17:13 • Luke 10:20 • Revelation 20:15
Healed and Saved by Him Alone	Jeremiah 17:14 • Isaiah 53:5 • Acts 4:12
Lord of the Sabbath, Rest for the Burdened	Jeremiah 17:21-27 • Mark 2:27-28 • Matthew 11:28-30

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 17 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the cursed man and the blessed man, the deceitful heart, and the Sabbath sermon at the gates
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 17](#) - sustained treatment of the Sabbath section from a Sabbath-keeping perspective
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 17](#) - exposition of the two-trees contrast and the heart that only Yahweh can search

Jeremiah 17 - Opening Intro

This chapter is where Jeremiah stops describing a nation and starts describing a person - any person, including the one reading it. Sin engraved on a heart. Trust placed somewhere. A root system either reaching for a river or clutching at salt.

And in the middle of it sits the verse most of us have heard quoted and few of us have heard finished. "The heart is deceitful above all things... who can know it?" is a question, not a verdict - and Yahweh answers it in the very next breath: I do. I search it. I try it.

Then, remarkably, the chapter does not end in introspection. It ends at a gate, with a wagon, on a Sabbath. The heart Yahweh searches is proven not in feeling but in whether you unload the cart.

Before we read, carry this honestly: the test of where your trust rests is rarely dramatic. It usually looks like an ordinary decision on an ordinary seventh day.

Jeremiah 17:1-27 (WEB)

1 “The sin of Judah is written with a pen of iron, and with the point of a diamond. It is engraved on the tablet of their heart, and on the horns of your altars.”^{13,14}

2 Even their children remember their altars and their Asherah poles by the green trees on the high hills.

3 My mountain in the field, I will give your substance and all your treasures for a plunder, and your high places, because of sin, throughout all your borders.

4 You, even of yourself, will discontinue from your heritage that I gave you. I will cause you to serve your enemies in the land which you don’t know, for you have kindled a fire in my anger which will burn forever.”

5 Yahweh says: “Cursed is the man who trusts in man, relies on strength of flesh, and whose heart departs from Yahweh.”¹⁵

6 For he will be like a bush in the desert, and will not see when good comes, but will inhabit the parched places in the wilderness, an uninhabited salt land.

7 “Blessed is the man who trusts in Yahweh, and whose confidence is in Yahweh.

8 For he will be as a tree planted by the waters, who spreads out its roots by the river, and will not fear when heat comes, but its leaf will be green; and will not be concerned in the year of drought. It won’t cease from yielding fruit.”^{16,17}

9 The heart is deceitful above all things and it is exceedingly corrupt. Who can know it?¹⁸

10 “I, Yahweh, search the mind. I try the heart, even to give every man according to his ways, according to the fruit of his doings.”¹⁹

11 As the partridge that sits on eggs which she has not laid, so is he who gets riches, and not by right. In the middle of his days, they will leave him. At his end, he will be a fool.

12 A glorious throne, set on high from the beginning, is the place of our sanctuary.

¹³ Cross-Reference: [Job 19:24](#) • [2 Corinthians 3:3](#) - engraving that endures - iron pen in rock, contrasted with the Spirit writing on hearts of flesh

¹⁴ Messianic Connection: [Jeremiah 31:33](#) • [Hebrews 8:10](#) - the promise to write Torah on the very surface where sin is now engraved

¹⁵ Cross-Reference: [Isaiah 31:1](#) • [Psalm 118:8-9](#) - the futility of leaning on horses, chariots, and princes instead of on Yahweh

¹⁶ Cross-Reference: [Psalm 1:1-3](#) • [Ezekiel 47:12](#) - the tree planted by water whose leaf does not wither and whose fruit does not fail

¹⁷ Messianic Connection: [John 15:1-5](#) • [Revelation 22:1-2](#) - abiding in the true Vine, rooted beside the river that flows from the throne

¹⁸ Cross-Reference: [Genesis 6:5](#) • [Mark 7:21-23](#) - the heart as the origin of defilement, not merely its casualty

¹⁹ Messianic Connection: [John 2:24-25](#) • [Revelation 2:23](#) - the One who needed no testimony about man, who searches the minds and hearts

13 Yahweh, the hope of Israel, all who forsake you will be disappointed. Those who depart from me will be written in the earth, because they have forsaken Yahweh, the spring of living waters.^{20,21}

14 Heal me, O Yahweh, and I will be healed. Save me, and I will be saved; for you are my praise.²²

15 Behold, they tell me, "Where is Yahweh's word? Let it be fulfilled now."

16 As for me, I have not hurried from being a shepherd after you. I haven't desired the woeful day. You know. That which came out of my lips was before your face.

17 Don't be a terror to me. You are my refuge in the day of evil.

18 Let them be disappointed who persecute me, but let not me be disappointed. Let them be dismayed, but don't let me be dismayed. Bring on them the day of evil, and destroy them with double destruction.

19 Yahweh said this to me: "Go, and stand in the gate of the children of the people, through which the kings of Judah come in and by which they go out, and in all the gates of Jerusalem.

20 Tell them, 'Hear Yahweh's word, you kings of Judah, and all Judah, and all the inhabitants of Jerusalem, that enter in by these gates:

21 Yahweh says, "Be careful, and bear no burden on the Sabbath day, nor bring it in by the gates of Jerusalem.

22 Don't carry a burden out of your houses on the Sabbath day. Don't do any work, but make the Sabbath day holy, as I commanded your fathers.²³

23 But they didn't listen. They didn't turn their ear, but made their neck stiff, that they might not hear, and might not receive instruction.

24 It will happen, if you diligently listen to me," says Yahweh, "to bring in no burden through the gates of this city on the Sabbath day, but to make the Sabbath day holy, to do no work therein;²⁴

25 then there will enter in by the gates of this city kings and princes sitting on David's throne, riding in chariots and on horses, they, and their princes, the men of Judah, and the inhabitants of Jerusalem; and this city will remain forever.

26 They will come from the cities of Judah, and from the places around Jerusalem, from the land of Benjamin, from the lowland, from the hill country, and from the South, bringing burnt offerings, sacrifices, meal offerings, and frankincense, and bringing sacrifices of thanksgiving, to Yahweh's house.

²⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 2:13](#) • [Psalm 36:9](#) - the spring of living waters forsaken for cisterns that hold nothing

²¹ **Messianic Connection:** [John 7:37-38](#) • [Luke 10:20](#) - living water offered to the thirsty, and names written in heaven rather than in dust

²² **Messianic Connection:** [Isaiah 53:5](#) • [Acts 4:12](#) - healing by His wounds, and salvation in no other name

²³ **Cross-Reference:** [Exodus 20:8-11](#) • [Nehemiah 13:15-19](#) - the Sabbath command, and its later enforcement at these same Jerusalem gates

²⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 58:13-14](#) • [Leviticus 26:2](#) - Sabbath honored as a delight, with the promised inheritance bound to it

27 But if you will not listen to me to make the Sabbath day holy, and not to bear a burden and enter in at the gates of Jerusalem on the Sabbath day, then I will kindle a fire in its gates, and it will devour the palaces of Jerusalem. It will not be quenched. ""²⁵

²⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Mark 2:27-28](#) • [Matthew 11:28-30](#) - the Son of Man as Lord of the Sabbath, giving rest to those carrying heavy burdens

CHAPTER 18 - The Potter's House, the Refusal, and the Plot

Key Notes

- Jeremiah is sent down to the potter's house to receive a word he could not have received in the temple - the sermon is the workshop itself (Jeremiah 18:1-3).
- The vessel is marred in the potter's hand, and the potter does not discard the clay. He makes it again, another vessel, as it seemed good to him to make it (Jeremiah 18:4).
- The principle is then stated plainly: Yahweh's sovereignty over nations is real and it is responsive. Declared judgment is withdrawn when a nation turns; declared blessing is withdrawn when it rebels (Jeremiah 18:5-10).
- The offer is issued in the plainest possible terms - "return now, everyone from his evil way" - and is met with the most chilling answer in the book: "It is in vain" (Jeremiah 18:11-12).
- Yahweh points to the natural world to expose the unnatural thing: the snow of Lebanon does not fail, the cold mountain waters do not dry up, but His people have forgotten Him (Jeremiah 18:13-15).
- They have been made to stumble out of the ancient paths into byways - roads that were never built up, leading to a land of astonishment and hissing (Jeremiah 18:15-17).
- The response to the message is a conspiracy against the messenger: priest, wise man, and prophet agree that Jeremiah can simply be struck with the tongue and ignored (Jeremiah 18:18).
- Jeremiah answers with raw, unedited lament - evil repaid for good, a pit dug for the very soul that stood before Yahweh to speak good on their behalf (Jeremiah 18:19-23).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Potter and the Clay	Jeremiah 18:1-6 • Isaiah 64:8 • Isaiah 29:16 • Romans 9:20-21
Conditional Judgment, Conditional Blessing	Jeremiah 18:7-10 • Jonah 3:10 • Ezekiel 33:13-16
"It Is in Vain" - the Settled Refusal	Jeremiah 18:12 • Jeremiah 2:25 • Proverbs 29:1
Forgetting Yahweh, Turning to Vanity	Jeremiah 18:15 • Jeremiah 2:32 • Deuteronomy 32:18
The Ancient Paths Abandoned	Jeremiah 18:15 • Jeremiah 6:16 • Proverbs 22:28
Plots Devised Against the Prophet	Jeremiah 18:18 • Jeremiah 11:19 • Psalm 31:13
Evil Repaid for Good	Jeremiah 18:20 • Psalm 35:12 • Psalm 109:4-5
A Pit Dug for the Righteous	Jeremiah 18:20-22 • Psalm 57:6 • Psalm 7:15

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Marred Vessel Remade, Not Discarded	Jeremiah 18:4 • 2 Corinthians 5:17 • Ephesians 2:10
The Potter's Hand and the Vessels of Mercy	Jeremiah 18:6 • Romans 9:21-23 • 2 Timothy 2:20-21
The Potter's Field and the Thirty Pieces	Jeremiah 18:2 • Zechariah 11:12-13 • Matthew 27:7-10
Return While the Offer Still Stands	Jeremiah 18:11 • Matthew 3:2 • Acts 3:19
Priest, Sage, and Elder Taking Counsel Together	Jeremiah 18:18 • Matthew 26:3-4 • John 11:53
The Righteous One Who Prayed for His Persecutors	Jeremiah 18:20 • Luke 23:34 • 1 Peter 2:23

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 18 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the potter's house sign-act and the conditional nature of the declared word
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 18](#) - covenant-framed reading of Yahweh's relenting and the people's refusal
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 18](#) - careful handling of the potter passage and its later use in Romans 9

Jeremiah 18 - Opening Intro

Yahweh does not explain this one. He sends Jeremiah on an errand - down the hill, to a workshop, to watch a man work - and lets the sight do the teaching.

What Jeremiah sees is not a potter smashing a failed pot. He sees a potter whose hands never leave the clay. The vessel is marred, and the wheel keeps turning, and the same hands begin again. That is the picture Yahweh chooses for Himself before He says a single word about judgment.

And it matters enormously that the very next thing He says is conditional. "If that nation turns from their evil, I will relent." The clay is not passive in this passage. It answers. And Judah's answer - "It is in vain" - is what turns a workshop into a courtroom.

Before we read, sit with the tension: the hand that can remake you is the same hand you can refuse. Sovereignty here is not fate. It is a craftsman waiting to see whether the clay will yield.

Jeremiah 18:1-23 (WEB)

- 1 The word which came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, saying,
- 2 “Arise, and go down to the potter’s house, and there I will cause you to hear my words.”²⁶
- 3 Then I went down to the potter’s house, and behold, he was making something on the wheels.
- 4 When the vessel that he made of the clay was marred in the hand of the potter, he made it again another vessel, as seemed good to the potter to make it.^{27,28}
- 5 Then Yahweh’s word came to me, saying,
- 6 “House of Israel, can’t I do with you as this potter?” says Yahweh. “Behold, as the clay in the potter’s hand, so are you in my hand, house of Israel.
- 7 At the instant I speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to pluck up and to break down and to destroy it;
- 8 if that nation, concerning which I have spoken, turns from their evil, I will repent of the evil that I thought to do to them.”²⁹
- 9 At the instant I speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to build and to plant it;
- 10 if they do that which is evil in my sight, that they not obey my voice, then I will repent of the good with which I said I would benefit them.
- 11 “Now therefore, speak to the men of Judah, and to the inhabitants of Jerusalem, saying, ‘Yahweh says: “Behold, I frame evil against you, and devise a plan against you. Everyone return from his evil way now, and amend your ways and your doings.”’³⁰
- 12 But they say, ‘It is in vain; for we will walk after our own plans, and we will each follow the stubbornness of his evil heart.’”³¹
- 13 Therefore Yahweh says: “Ask now among the nations, ‘Who has heard such things?’ The virgin of Israel has done a very horrible thing.

²⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [Zechariah 11:12-13](#) • [Matthew 27:7-10](#) - the potter’s field bought with the thirty pieces of silver, tied by Matthew to Jeremiah

²⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 64:8](#) • [Isaiah 29:16](#) - Yahweh as the Potter and Israel as the clay - the creature’s place before its Maker

²⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [2 Corinthians 5:17](#) • [Ephesians 2:10](#) - the marred vessel remade into a new creation, His workmanship

²⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jonah 3:10](#) • [Ezekiel 33:13-16](#) - declared judgment relented when a nation actually turns from its evil

³⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 3:2](#) • [Acts 3:19](#) - the same call carried forward - repent and turn again, that times of refreshing may come

³¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 2:25](#) • [Proverbs 29:1](#) - the hardened answer of a people who have stopped being persuadable

14 Will the snow of Lebanon fail from the rock of the field? Will the cold waters that flow down from afar be dried up?

15 For my people have forgotten me. They have burned incense to false gods. They have been made to stumble in their ways, in the ancient paths, to walk in byways, in a way not built up;³²

16 to make their land an astonishment, and a perpetual hissing. Everyone who passes thereby will be astonished, and shake his head.

17 I will scatter them as with an east wind before the enemy. I will show them the back, and not the face, in the day of their calamity.

18 Then they said, "Come, and let us devise plans against Jeremiah; for the law won't perish from the priest, nor counsel from the wise, nor the word from the prophet. Come, and let us strike him with the tongue, and let us not give heed to any of his words."^{33,34}

19 Give heed to me, Yahweh, and listen to the voice of those who contend with me.

20 Should evil be recompensed for good? For they have dug a pit for my soul. Remember how I stood before you to speak good for them, to turn away your wrath from them.^{35,36}

21 Therefore deliver up their children to the famine, and give them over to the power of the sword. Let their wives become childless, and widows. Let their men be killed, and their young men struck by the sword in battle.

22 Let a cry be heard from their houses, when you bring a troop suddenly on them; for they have dug a pit to take me, and hidden snares for my feet.

23 Yet, Yahweh, you know all their counsel against me to kill me. Don't forgive their iniquity. Don't blot out their sin from your sight, Let them be overthrown before you. Deal with them in the time of your anger.

³² Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 6:16](#) • [Deuteronomy 32:18](#) - the ancient paths refused, and the Rock who fathered them forgotten

³³ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 11:19](#) • [Psalm 31:13](#) - plots devised in secret against the faithful messenger, who is the last to hear of them

³⁴ Messianic Connection: [Matthew 26:3-4](#) • [John 11:53](#) - priest, scribe, and elder taking counsel together against the Righteous One

³⁵ Cross-Reference: [Psalm 35:12](#) • [Psalm 109:4-5](#) - evil rendered for good to the one who stood in prayer for his accusers

³⁶ Messianic Connection: [Luke 23:34](#) • [1 Peter 2:23](#) - the greater Intercessor who prayed for the very men who dug the pit

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 16-18

- A prophet's own life conscripted as the sermon - obedience that costs marriage, mourning, and company
- Judgment announced and restoration promised in the same breath, with a second exodus greater than the first
- Two root systems, two futures - trust in flesh that withers, trust in Yahweh that stays green in drought
- A heart no one can read except the One who made it, and who says plainly that He searches it
- The Sabbath as the ordinary, concrete gate where covenant loyalty is either carried or set down
- Sovereignty as a working hand rather than a fixed script - the marred vessel remade, not discarded
- The offer of return standing open until a people themselves close it with "It is in vain"
- The cost of carrying the word: conspiracy from priest, sage, and prophet, and lament brought honestly to Yahweh

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who asked Jeremiah to give up his own household for the sake of the message give us hearts willing to be spent, and may He never let our obedience become a performance we admire rather than a life we live.

May He gather us as He promised to gather Israel out of the north country, and may our testimony be not only what He brought us out of, but what He is bringing us into.

May He plant us by the waters, with roots that reach past the dry season, so that when the heat comes we do not notice it the way the desert shrub does - and may our leaf stay green when everything around us browns.

May He search the heart we cannot read ourselves, and may we welcome the searching rather than hide from it, knowing that the One who tries the heart is the One who heals it.

May He teach us to honor His Sabbath as a delight and not a burden, and may our ordinary obedience at ordinary gates testify louder than anything we say.

And when we find ourselves marred on the wheel, may we not leap out of His hands - may we yield, and let the Potter make us again, another vessel, as it seems good to Him to make it.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.